

# Meridian & Associates LLP

Global Professional Services

## Business Continuity and Disaster Recovery Plan

Version 5.2

Effective Date: January 2026

Classification: Confidential

Prepared by the Office of Strategic Communications

Meridian & Associates LLP

### **CONFIDENTIAL**

This document contains proprietary information. Do not distribute  
outside of authorized RFP response teams without written consent.

## Table of Contents

---

|    |                                           |
|----|-------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Purpose and Scope                         |
| 2  | Governance and Organizational Structure   |
| 3  | Business Impact Analysis                  |
| 4  | Recovery Objectives                       |
| 5  | Data Center and Infrastructure Redundancy |
| 6  | Backup and Replication Strategy           |
| 7  | Pandemic and Workforce Disruption         |
| 8  | Communication and Escalation              |
| 9  | Testing and Exercise Program              |
| 10 | Third-Party Dependency Management         |
| 11 | Cyber Incident and Ransomware Recovery    |
| 12 | Client-Specific BCDR Customization        |
| 13 | Vendor Dependency Matrix                  |

## 1. Purpose and Scope

---

This Business Continuity and Disaster Recovery (BCDR) Plan establishes the framework, procedures, and responsibilities for maintaining critical business operations and recovering technology infrastructure in the event of a disruption. The plan covers all Meridian & Associates LLP operations globally, including client-facing service delivery, internal business functions, and supporting technology infrastructure.

The plan is designed to address a range of disruption scenarios including: natural disasters (earthquake, flood, hurricane, wildfire), technology failures (data center outage, network failure, ransomware attack), pandemic or health emergencies, civil unrest or geopolitical events, and critical supplier failures. The plan is reviewed and updated at least semi-annually, with ad hoc updates triggered by significant organizational changes, lessons learned from exercises, or emerging threats.

## 2. Governance and Organizational Structure

---

- Executive Sponsor: Chief Operating Officer (COO)
- BCDR Program Director: VP of Enterprise Resilience, reporting to the COO
- Crisis Management Team (CMT): COO, CISO, General Counsel, Chief People Officer, Head of Communications, Regional Managing Partners
- Business Continuity Coordinators: Designated in each service line and major office (142 total)
- DR Engineering Team: 28 dedicated infrastructure engineers responsible for DR environment maintenance and failover execution

## 3. Business Impact Analysis

---

Meridian conducts a comprehensive Business Impact Analysis (BIA) annually to classify all business processes and technology systems by criticality. Systems are classified into four tiers:

- Tier 1 -- Mission Critical: Revenue-generating client delivery systems, email and collaboration, identity and access management, financial systems. Downtime tolerance: < 4 hours.
- Tier 2 -- Business Critical: CRM, project management, time and expense, knowledge management. Downtime tolerance: < 12 hours.
- Tier 3 -- Business Important: Learning management, internal portals, analytics dashboards. Downtime tolerance: < 48 hours.
- Tier 4 -- Non-Critical: Archive systems, development/test environments. Downtime tolerance: < 5 business days.

## 4. Recovery Objectives

---

Recovery objectives are defined by system tier:

- Tier 1 -- RPO: 1 hour, RTO: 4 hours. Synchronous replication to secondary data center. Automated failover with manual confirmation.
- Tier 2 -- RPO: 4 hours, RTO: 12 hours. Asynchronous replication with 4-hour snapshots.
- Tier 3 -- RPO: 24 hours, RTO: 48 hours. Daily backup replication.

- Tier 4 -- RPO: 48 hours, RTO: 5 business days. Weekly backup replication.

These objectives have been validated through testing and are contractually committed to clients whose SLAs reference our BCDR capabilities.

## 5. Data Center and Infrastructure Redundancy

---

### 5.1 Primary and Secondary Data Centers

- Primary Data Center: Equinix CH3, Chicago, Illinois -- Tier IV design, 99.995% uptime SLA. 2,400 sq ft dedicated cage, N+1 power and cooling redundancy.
- Secondary Data Center: CyrusOne Sterling, Virginia -- Geographically separated by 580 miles. Active-passive configuration with automated failover capability.
- European Data Center: Equinix LD8, London -- Serves EMEA operations with data sovereignty controls ensuring EU data remains within the EEA.
- APAC Data Center: Equinix SG3, Singapore -- Serves APAC operations.

### 5.2 Cloud Infrastructure

- Primary cloud provider: Microsoft Azure (multi-region, paired regions for DR).
- Secondary cloud provider: AWS (used for specific workloads and as tertiary DR option).
- All cloud workloads deployed across minimum two availability zones.
- Cross-region replication for all Tier 1 and Tier 2 cloud services.

## 6. Backup and Replication Strategy

---

- Tier 1 systems: Synchronous replication (zero data loss) between primary and secondary sites. Additional daily backups retained for 90 days.
- Tier 2 systems: Asynchronous replication every 4 hours. Daily backups retained for 60 days.
- Tier 3/4 systems: Daily incremental backups, weekly full backups. Retained for 30 days.
- All backups encrypted (AES-256) and integrity-verified via automated checksums.
- Annual backup restoration testing: 100% of Tier 1 systems, 50% of Tier 2 systems tested annually.
- Immutable backup copies maintained in air-gapped storage for ransomware resilience.

## 7. Pandemic and Workforce Disruption

---

Meridian's pandemic response protocol was extensively refined during COVID-19 and has been maintained in a state of readiness. Key elements:

- 100% remote work capability -- All 68,000+ professionals can operate fully remotely within 24 hours of activation. VPN and virtual desktop infrastructure scaled to support concurrent full workforce access.
- Split-team operations -- Critical functions operate with geographically dispersed A/B teams to prevent single-site workforce loss.
- Supply chain for hardware -- Pre-positioned inventory of 5,000 laptops and peripherals for rapid deployment.
- Mental health and wellbeing support -- Expanded EAP services, manager training on remote team wellbeing, and

flexible work arrangements during extended disruptions.

- Trigger thresholds: Monitoring tier activated when WHO raises alert level; full protocol activated upon pandemic declaration or when >5% of any office reports illness.

## 8. Communication and Escalation

---

### 8.1 Communication Cascade

- T+0 minutes: Incident detected and reported to BCDR Program Director and on-call CMT member.
- T+15 minutes: CMT convened (virtual war room). Initial assessment of scope and severity.
- T+30 minutes: Crisis communication drafted for internal distribution.
- T+1 hour: Employee notification via Everbridge mass notification system (SMS, email, push notification, voice call).
- T+2 hours: Client notification for affected engagements (via Engagement Partners).
- T+4 hours: External stakeholder communication (regulators, insurers) if required.

### 8.2 Communication Channels

- Primary: Everbridge Mass Notification Platform
- Secondary: Microsoft Teams (dedicated Crisis Channel)
- Tertiary: Satellite phone network (12 units distributed to CMT members and regional leads)
- Backup: Personal mobile phones via pre-registered contact tree

## 9. Testing and Exercise Program

---

Meridian conducts a rigorous annual testing program to validate BCDR capabilities:

- Full DR Failover Test -- Conducted annually (most recent: September 2025). Full failover of all Tier 1 systems to secondary data center. RTO achieved: 3 hours 12 minutes (within 4-hour target). RPO achieved: 47 minutes (within 1-hour target).
- Tabletop Exercises -- Two per year with CMT participation. Scenarios include ransomware attack, multi-site natural disaster, and critical vendor failure.
- Departmental BCP Tests -- Each service line conducts at least one business continuity exercise annually.
- Communication Cascade Tests -- Quarterly Everbridge tests with >95% acknowledgment rate target. FY2025 average: 97.2% within 30 minutes.
- Third-Party DR Validation -- Annual review of critical vendor DR capabilities and contractual SLAs.

## 10. Third-Party Dependency Management

---

Meridian identifies and manages third-party dependencies that could impact business continuity:

- Critical Vendor Registry: 47 vendors classified as critical (single point of failure or essential to Tier 1 processes).
- Contractual Requirements: All critical vendors must demonstrate BCDR capabilities with RTOs equal to or better than Meridian's requirements.
- Annual DR Evidence Collection: SOC 2 reports, DR test results, and BCP documentation reviewed annually for all critical vendors.

- Diversification Policy: No single vendor may represent more than 30% of spend in any critical service category. Alternative vendors pre-qualified for top 20 critical services.
- Escrow Agreements: Source code escrow for all critical bespoke software vendors.

## 11. Cyber Incident and Ransomware Recovery

---

Ransomware and destructive cyber attacks represent one of the highest-probability, highest-impact disruption scenarios. Meridian maintains a dedicated Cyber Incident Recovery Plan that supplements the general BCDR framework:

### 11.1 Ransomware-Specific Controls

- Immutable backups: All Tier 1 and Tier 2 system backups are stored in air-gapped, immutable storage (write-once, read-many). Backup integrity verified daily via automated checksums.
- Network segmentation: Microsegmentation limits lateral movement. Delivery center networks are isolated from corporate networks and from each other.
- Endpoint isolation: CrowdStrike Falcon real-time response enables one-click isolation of compromised endpoints within seconds of detection.
- Ransomware-specific playbooks: Pre-approved response playbooks for 6 ransomware scenarios, tested quarterly in tabletop exercises with the Crisis Management Team.
- Decryption capability: Relationship with law enforcement (FBI, NCA, Europol) and ransomware decryptor databases (No More Ransom) for recovery without payment.

### 11.2 Recovery Procedures

- Containment: Immediate network isolation of affected segments. Kill switch for all outbound internet connectivity if active data exfiltration detected.
- Forensic investigation: Retained incident response firm (CrowdStrike Services) on standby with guaranteed 2-hour response SLA. Forensic investigation runs in parallel with recovery.
- Clean recovery: Systems rebuilt from verified clean images and immutable backups. No data restored from potentially compromised backup snapshots.
- Identity reset: Full credential rotation for all administrative accounts. MFA re-enrollment for affected users.
- Ransom payment policy: Meridian's policy is not to pay ransoms. This position is endorsed by the Board of Partners and communicated to insurers. Exception requires unanimous CMT approval and legal counsel sign-off.
- Recovery time target: Full Tier 1 recovery from ransomware scenario within 8 hours. Most recent test (September 2025): achieved in 6 hours 22 minutes.

## 12. Client-Specific BCDR Customization

---

Meridian recognizes that many clients -- particularly in financial services, healthcare, and government -- have BCDR requirements that exceed the firm's standard framework. The firm offers client-specific BCDR customization through the following mechanisms:

- Client BCDR questionnaire: Completed during engagement onboarding to identify enhanced requirements (e.g., tighter RTOs, dedicated recovery environments, regulatory-specific notifications).
- Dedicated recovery environments: For Tier 1 clients (annual fees >\$10M), Meridian can provision dedicated DR environments with client-specified configurations, tested semi-annually.

- Client-specific tabletop exercises: Annual joint tabletop exercises with the client's BC team to validate end-to-end recovery across both organizations. Offered to all clients with managed services contracts.
- Regulatory alignment: BCDR plans tailored to sector-specific regulations including DORA (EU financial services), OCC Heightened Standards (U.S. banking), and CPS 230 (APRA, Australia).
- Client notification SLAs: Default notification within 24 hours of a material incident. Accelerated notification (4-hour or 1-hour) available contractually for critical engagements.
- Client audit rights: All managed services clients have contractual rights to audit Meridian's BCDR capabilities annually, including observation of DR failover tests.

### 13. Vendor Dependency Matrix

---

The following summarizes Meridian's critical vendor dependencies, diversification status, and contractual BCDR commitments for the firm's most essential third-party services:

- Cloud Infrastructure (Microsoft Azure, primary): RTO contractual SLA 4 hours. Multi-region deployment across paired regions. Secondary provider: AWS (active for specific workloads). Diversification: Yes.
- Cloud Infrastructure (AWS, secondary): Used for 20% of workloads. Cross-region replication configured. Provides tertiary DR option for Azure-primary services. Diversification: Yes.
- Collaboration Platform (Microsoft 365): RTO contractual SLA 4 hours. Geo-redundant deployment. Offline access capability via cached Outlook/Teams. Alternative: Satellite phone network and backup email system. Diversification: Partial.
- SIEM/Security (Splunk Enterprise): RTO 2 hours. Deployed in active-active across two data centers. Alternative: Azure Sentinel as warm standby. Diversification: Yes.
- Endpoint Security (CrowdStrike Falcon): Cloud-native, multi-region. RTO < 1 hour. No single-vendor alternative but compensating controls (Windows Defender ATP) available. Diversification: Partial.
- Data Center Facilities (Equinix): Three facilities (Chicago, London, Singapore). Each site has independent contracts with separate power and cooling infrastructure. Geographic separation provides inherent diversification. Diversification: Yes.
- Telecommunications (multiple carriers): Primary: AT&T (Americas), BT (EMEA), Singtel (APAC). Secondary carriers in each region. SD-WAN overlay enables automated failover. Diversification: Yes.
- HR/Payroll (Workday): RTO 12 hours. Multi-tenant cloud with Workday-managed DR. Manual payroll processing procedures documented as fallback. Diversification: No (single vendor, assessed acceptable risk).